THE GHOSTWRITER FROM THE 6TH DIMENSION

ACT THREE

Written by

[Writer]

Original screenplay
Act Three, Draft 1. Continues from Act Two (page 61).
Concludes the feature.
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INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Rain on the window. The lamp burns amber.

The framed photograph lies face up on the table: a boy of nine on a slate ledge, a five-year-old girl in a yellow dress printed with ducks.

Theo sits with his hand flat beside it. The green notebook lies closed at his elbow. Nell stands in her dripping raincoat.

THEO
Tell me.

Nell pulls out the chair across from him and sits. She lays both hands flat on the table.

NELL
You were on the ledge.

THEO
I was home. I was writing.

NELL
You'd finished writing. You came to find me. You got there when Tomas had me in the middle of the pond. He was swimming us in.

THEO
I don't remember that.

NELL
He got us to the ledge. You were standing on it. You were nine. You'd run all the way.

At the head of the table, in the amber light, Theodore sits with his hands folded. Theo looks at him. Nell keeps her eyes on Theo.

NELL (CONT'D)
He pushed me up toward you. He said, "Theo, take her hand." He said it twice.

Theo's right hand lies on the table. His fingers uncurl a half inch.

NELL (CONT'D)
You put your arm out. And then you didn't.

THEO
Why?

NELL
I don't know. I was five. I was looking at your face. You were looking at him.

THEO
At Tomas.

NELL
Not at my hand. At him.

Theo's lips part. Nothing comes out.

THEODORE
She was five, Theo. Memory is a draft. I'm the fair copy.

Theo turns his head toward the head of the table. Nell watches his eyes land on the empty chair.

THEO
Be quiet.

NELL
He's here.

THEO
Yes.

NELL
Where?

THEO
At the end of the table.

Nell looks at the empty chair. Her jaw sets.

NELL (CONT'D)
I used to be afraid of Theodore. Mom read that notebook at this table every night. "Theodore reached into the black water and took her hand, and." She said it like a prayer. I was six. I thought it was a bedtime story.

THEO
It was a wish.

NELL
She wanted a boy who took my hand. So she made one up and read him to herself until he was real enough to be afraid of.

At Theo's open collar, the brown-black line along his collarbone pales.

THEO
What happened after?

NELL
He pushed me onto the stone. I crawled out by myself. Tomas held on to the ledge with one arm. He looked at you.

THEO
What did he say?

NELL
Nothing. His arm slid off. He went under. He didn't come up.

THEO
And I--

NELL
You stood there. Until a quarry man came running. Then you walked home.

THEO
Dry.

NELL
Mom counted you in. That's what she said when they asked her. "Tomas came back wet. Theo came back dry. I counted them both in."

THEO
Both.

NELL
You and him. She counts him in every day. "One in. Two in." It was never me she was counting.

Theo shuts his eyes.

THEO
Why didn't you tell me?

NELL
I told you when I was nineteen. You said you were home. You said it so hard you stopped breathing. They kept you in a hospital for nine days. Dad said never again.

THEO
You left.

NELL
I changed my name and I left. I came back when Mom started forgetting.

THEO
Why?

NELL
Because when she forgets, there's nobody left who remembers him.

She turns the photograph and slides it toward him.

NELL (CONT'D)
His mother still leaves marigolds at the quarry every Friday. Nobody has ever told her what happened.

Theo looks at the photograph. The boy's hands hang at his sides. The girl's small hand is open, an inch from his sleeve.

From upstairs, faint, in Theo's own voice:

THEO'S VOICE (O.S.)
June. Come see the door.

Theo's head snaps toward the ceiling. Nell looks up at it. Nothing. At the head of the table, Theodore looks at Theo and smiles.

THEO
That was me.

NELL
What?

Theo is on his feet.

THEO
That was my voice. June!

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - UPSTAIRS HALL - NIGHT

Theo takes the stairs three at a time. June's door stands open. The bed is empty, the covers thrown back. The window is shut.

He checks the closet. The bathroom.

THEO
June!

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - NIGHT

The front door stands open to the rain. The chain hangs loose.

Nell stands on the threshold, looking down.

On the porch boards, bare wet footprints: a child's, small, and beside them a second set, larger.

Theo comes down the stairs and stops beside her. The prints lead off the porch and across the lawn toward the quarry path, the small ones and the large ones together.

On the lawn, Theodore stands in the rain. The rain falls around him and does not touch him.

THEODORE
The wet one has her. I did ask what he wants.

Theo steps onto the porch.

THEO
That was my voice upstairs.

THEODORE
Was it? Sign, Theo. She'll wake at home with her shoes by the bed, having never left.

THEO
Where is she?

THEODORE
Where the door is.

He turns and walks toward the quarry path. The rain keeps its distance. He leaves no prints.

NELL
Who are you talking to?

THEO
Him.

NELL
Where is she?

Theo points toward the quarry. Nell looks at the prints.

NELL (CONT'D)
Those aren't just hers.

THEO
He took her.

NELL
Tomas pulled me out of that water.

THEO
You don't know what he is now.

NELL
I know what he was.

Theo shoves his hand into his coat pocket for the phone. His fingers find a thin, cold shaft.

He pulls it out: a chewed pencil, tooth marks along its length, water beading on it.

NELL (CONT'D)
That's Tomas's.

THEO
How do you know?

NELL
Teeth marks.

Theo closes his fist around the pencil. He goes back inside, takes the green notebook from the kitchen table, and pushes it into his coat.

He thumbs his phone as he runs out.

MARA (V.O.)
Theo?

THEO
June's gone. The quarry pond. Come now.

MARA (V.O.)
I'm putting my shoes on.

EXT. QUARRY POND - PREDAWN

Gray light. Fog lies on the pond. Slate shelves step down to a flat ledge at the water's edge.

On the ledge sit a pair of pink sneakers, side by side. Between the sneakers and the water, two large bare wet footprints are planted side by side, facing the sneakers.

The pond is black and flat. The paling sky does not show in it.

Theo and Nell come down the steps. Headlights swing across the rim. Mara runs down the path with a coil of yellow nylon tow rope over her shoulder.

MARA
Where is she?

THEO
In there.

MARA
In--

NELL
The pond.

Mara drops the rope and takes off her coat. She steps into the water. It reaches her ankles.

She walks ten feet out. It stays at her ankles. She stamps. Slate rings under the water.

MARA
It's solid.

NELL
It won't let you in.

THEO
It let her.

Mara wades back. She picks up the rope, loops it around Theo's waist, and ties a knot. She puts the coil in Nell's hands.

MARA
Feet braced. If it goes slack, I pull.

THEO
It won't pull me back.

MARA
I'll pull anyway.

Nell wraps the rope twice around her forearm. Mara stands behind her and takes the rope in both hands.

Theo steps to the edge of the ledge. His sneakers touch the pink ones.

He stands. His right arm rises a few inches from his side and stops, shaking.

The fog moves across the pond. Nobody speaks. A long time passes.

NELL
Theo.

He does not move.

MARA
Go.

THEO
Nell. I'm sorry.

NELL
After.

Theo steps off the ledge.

EXT. QUARRY POND - UNDERWATER - CONTINUOUS

Black water. Pale gray sheets of paper drift past Theo's face, turning, faint handwriting showing through them.

He sinks through them. They part around him and close above.

His feet touch bottom.

INT. THE VERSO - CONTINUOUS

A black floor under half an inch of water, mirroring everything above it. Theo stands on it. His clothes are dry.

The rope at his waist trails up into the dark and out of sight.

Slate shelves rise in tiers into the dark: a quarry wall with no top.

Thousands of translucent sheets of paper hang in rows from the dark, each the size of a door. Handwriting shows through them.

Gray flakes fall through the air and settle on the water without a ripple.

Theo walks. Each footstep sounds half a second before it lands.

THEO
June!

His voice comes back reversed, half a second late.

Wet bare footprints cross the black floor ahead of him, one after another, and lead between two rows of hanging sheets.

He follows them. Beyond the rows, squares of floor are lit by single hanging bulbs.

In the first square, twelve children in school clothes sit cross-legged in rows, each holding an open book. Every page is blank. They read.

The children lift their heads together and look at Theo. Then they look down at their books again.

In the second square, a man in a wedding suit stands with one hand raised to knock, his mouth open on the first syllable of a word. He does not move.

In the third, a woman in a hospital gown holds a telephone receiver to her ear. The cord ends in the air.

In the fourth, a school desk. WALTER PRUITT (74) sits at it in his cardigan, typing on a typewriter with no paper in it. The keys move. They make no sound.

Theo stops.

THEO
Walter.

Walter looks up. His face is pleasant and vague.

WALTER
Can I help you?

THEO
Walter Pruitt. Forty-one books. Not a name on one of them.

Walter's hands stop above the keys. He looks at them.

WALTER
I used to know what these were for.

THEO
They wrote.

WALTER
Did they? I keep thinking there's a page.

THEO
You asked me to put your name somewhere. I will.

WALTER
Did I? That was good of me.

He smiles, nods, and goes back to typing. The keys move. They make no sound.

Theo follows the prints. At the end of the last row, a single wooden door stands alone on the black floor, with no wall around it. Amber light spills through its edges.

The prints stop at the door. Theo opens it.

INT. THE VERSO - THE STUDY - CONTINUOUS

A warm room inside the dark. Amber lamplight. The yellow rope at Theo's waist trails in behind him over the threshold.

Every wall is papered floor to ceiling in handwriting, each sentence struck through with a single line.

Theo reads a few as he enters:

I was not there.
It was my fault.
Forgive me.
I love her more than the work.

Shelves hold books in the same handwriting on their spines: SLATE, A ROOM CALLED AFTERNOON, THE UNDERSTORY.

A desk with a green-shaded lamp, a fountain pen, a tray with two steaming cups of tea, and a single sheet of cream paper. A leather armchair.

In the armchair June sleeps in her pajamas, a blank book open on her lap. Lines of faint handwriting cover her palms. They are fading.

Theodore sits at the desk in shirtsleeves, his hands folded.

THEODORE
Come in. Mind the tea.

Theo crosses to June. He touches her cheek. She does not wake. He lifts her hand and looks at the fading lines.

THEO
Wake her.

THEODORE
I can't. She doesn't belong to me. She belongs to the last page.

He taps the cream sheet.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Sign, and she wakes in her bed with her shoes by the door, having never left. Refuse, and she stays until she's something that stays.

Theo picks up the sheet. Brown-black handwriting covers it. At the bottom, in the same hand: Theodore Lindqvist, with a blank space beside it.

THEO
"I reached into the black water and took her hand, and she lived, and I lived, and no one else was ever in that water."

He sets it down.

THEO (CONT'D)
No one else.

THEODORE
No one.

THEO
There was a boy.

THEODORE
Sit. Have your tea. It's been a long night.

Theo does not sit.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Do you know what's in this room? Everything you dropped on the way here.

He opens a hand toward the shelves and the walls.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Perry Street. The back bedroom with the radiator. "A Room Called Afternoon," there, between the others. Your father's whistle. The first sentence of "Slate."

THEO
"The kitchen smelled like wet stone."

THEODORE
I wrote that one.

THEO
I wrote that.

THEODORE
You typed it at three in the morning in a trance. You told a whole radio audience you take dictation. You never once asked who was talking.

Theo looks at the walls: the struck-through lines in the handwriting of the pages.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
I hold everything you couldn't carry. Elise, too.

THEO
Who?

THEODORE
June Elise. Your grandmother's name. You paid it the night you said "in a minute" out loud, in the kitchen, to your daughter's face. Say her name, Theo. The whole thing.

THEO
June--

His mouth works. Nothing follows.

THEODORE
You see. I'm not taking your life. I'm the part of you that's been holding it.

Theo kneels beside the armchair. He puts his forehead against June's knee.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
You were nine. You froze. Anyone would have. I'm not asking you to forget it. I'm asking you to forgive it. And the only way anyone ever forgives a thing like that is to give it a different ending. That's all a story is.

THEO
It happened.

THEODORE
It happened. And now it happened differently. Your sister doesn't have to carry your hand not coming. Your mother dies believing in you. Your daughter has a father who listens. Who loses?

THEO
The boy.

THEODORE
The boy never has to drown. Nobody has to miss him. His mother never loses him. That's the kindest line on this page.

THEO
She never has him.

THEODORE
Is that so much worse?

Theo lifts his head.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
She's in Vermont right now, asleep, with a jar of marigolds on her counter for a boy nobody remembers. Thirty-eight years of Fridays. Wouldn't you like to let her stop?

Theo says nothing. On his neck and jaw, brown-black lines surface and spread.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
One name. One line. Under mine.

He lifts the fountain pen and holds it out. Only a few faint lines are left on June's palms.

Theo takes the pen. The lines climb his jaw toward his mouth. He sits at the desk. He bends over the page.

The nib touches the paper beside Theodore's printed name. Theo draws the first stroke of a T.

Theodore leans forward. His eyes shine.

Theo stops. The pen hangs over the page.

THEO
Nell said he told me to take her hand.

THEODORE
She was five.

THEO
She was there.

He lowers the pen to the desk.

THEODORE
Theo.

THEO
I stood there.

THEODORE
You were nine.

THEO
I was nine. I stood there. I had her hand in front of me and I didn't take it.

The lines on his jaw and neck lift off his skin in wisps of steam.

THEODORE
You don't know why.

THEO
No.

THEODORE
Then don't. Sign. You never have to know.

THEO
I want to know.

Theo pushes the pen aside. He picks up the cream page and turns it over.

The back is blank. Theodore rises halfway out of his chair.

THEODORE
That's scrap. Nothing is written there.

Theo tilts the page toward the green lamp. The light rakes across the paper. Shadows fill thin grooves pressed deep into the fibers: slanted cursive, a boy's hand.

The letters stay where they are.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Put it down.

THEO
"Theo."

Gray rises into the grooves as he reads. A pencil line darkens under each word.

THEODORE
Theo. Stop.

THEO
"Take her hand."

The steam stops rising from the two cups of tea. The struck-through sentences on the walls shiver.

Theodore's arm shoots across the desk for the page. His hand stops an inch above the paper and flattens against nothing. He pushes. His arm shakes. The hand will not go down.

THEODORE
Don't.

It is a child's voice, high and thin: the voice that said "in a minute."

Theo looks up at Theodore's face.

THEO
There you are.

The shaking leaves Theodore's arm. His face smooths. He lowers himself into the chair.

THEODORE
I don't know what you mean.

Theo looks down at the page. A third line darkens under the second.

THEO
"Look."

The lamp dims. The struck-through sentences fade from the walls until the walls are tracing paper. Behind them, lit rectangles appear one at a time, a row of windows.

EXT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN WINDOW - NIGHT (REPLAY)

Rain on the outside of the glass. Behind it, the lit kitchen: Theo at the table with his eyes closed, reading aloud, smiling.

A soaked boy faces the window. His wet hand slaps the glass. Again. Again. Theo does not open his eyes.

In the pane beside Theo, his reflection leans to the glass and breathes on it. Fog spreads. A finger writes in it. From this side the letters run backward: UOY KNAHT.

The boy's hand slides down the pane. It leaves the shape of a palm and five fingers in the water.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - HALL - NIGHT (REPLAY)

The hall in blue light. A tall boy walks down it, barefoot and soaked. A wet print forms under each step.

At the white door he stops. He lays his palm flat on the paint, then his forehead.

At the far end, Theo comes out of the kitchen with a mop and mops toward him, hard and fast, scrubbing out the prints one at a time.

The boy does not move. The mop reaches his heels and sweeps through his ankles.

His shoulders shake.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - CELLAR - NIGHT (REPLAY)

Theo backs against the stone steps with a green notebook raised between himself and the dark. His mouth shapes a name.

Two wet hands reach into the bulb's light. One closes on Theo's wrist and does not squeeze.

The other turns the notebook over and holds it open at the back cover: T.A. - CHIEF READER.

The hand lets go of the notebook and goes into a shorts pocket. It comes out holding a chewed pencil.

It presses the pencil into Theo's palm and folds his fingers over it, one at a time.

Theo wrenches free and runs. The stairs thunder.

The wet hands hang in the air at the height of his wrist. The fingers curl shut around nothing.

EXT. QUARRY TURNOUT - MORNING (REPLAY)

The back of the granite slab: rough, gray, unpolished. Through the stone, faint and reversed, a man kneels in the gravel and traces letters with two fingers.

A soaked boy faces the slab. He lays both palms flat on the granite and leans his weight into it.

Dust sifts down through the stone. The reversed letters slide away one at a time. New letters take their place, stroke by stroke: THEODORE LINDQVIST.

The boy's arms shake. He keeps his palms where they are.

Through the stone, a man in a vest holds out a hand to Theo. Theo looks at it. He takes it.

The boy's forehead drops against the granite.

EXT. SLATE DINER - NIGHT (REPLAY)

A wet sidewalk. Rain. A soaked boy faces the plate-glass window, rain running off his hair.

Inside, every booth is full. A banner over the counter reads WELCOME HOME, THEO. A pie on every table. A room applauding, the sound muffled to a flutter.

No one looks out.

In the booth by the door, Nell sits with her hands around a coffee cup. She is the only one not clapping.

She stands, leaves a bill under her saucer, and comes out. She passes the boy at arm's length and stops.

Her head turns an inch toward him. She turns her collar up and walks on into the rain.

The boy's head follows her until she is gone.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT (REPLAY)

The kitchen reversed: the stove on the opposite wall, water over the linoleum.

June reads aloud from a laptop, her eyes glazed, her bare feet under water. Theodore sits beside her with his chin on his hand, smiling.

A soaked boy faces the table. He steps up behind June and clamps a wet hand over her mouth. Her reading stops on the word she.

Theo's face comes at the boy out of the water, teeth bared. A fist.

The boy's head snaps sideways. He hits the stove and slides down it into the water.

He does not raise his hands. He sits with his palms open on his knees.

At Theo's shout, his head lifts.

EXT. QUARRY POND - NIGHT (REPLAY)

Moonlight. The pond, black and flat. A boy stands waist-deep thirty feet out with his arms stretched wide, facing the shore.

On the shore, Theo's flashlight clicks off. He calls across the water. His lips shape a name.

The boy lowers one arm. He points past Theo, up the hill.

At the top of the slope the farmhouse kitchen window glows amber. In it stands a man in a pressed white shirt, one hand flat on the glass, watching Theo.

Theo turns to the window. He runs for the house.

The boy's arm stays pointed at the window until Theo is out of sight.

EXT. QUARRY POND - PREDAWN (REPLAY)

Gray light. The slate ledge. A boy stands on it with his arms spread wide, facing the steps.

June comes down them in her pajamas and pink sneakers, her eyes open, her face blank. She sits on the ledge, pulls off the sneakers, and sets them side by side.

The boy steps in front of her. He shakes his head, again and again.

June stands. She does not look at him. She walks around his outstretched arm and steps off the ledge.

The black water closes over her. No ring spreads.

The boy wades in after her. At his chest the water stops him. He pushes down. The surface holds him up.

He stands in the pond with his arms stretched wide and his face turned to the hill. The farmhouse window glows amber. No one comes down.

INT. THE VERSO - THE STUDY - CONTINUOUS

The walls are thick with handwriting again. The lamp burns low. The two cups of tea are cold, a skin on each.

Theo sits with the page in both hands. Tears run down his face. He does not wipe them.

Theodore stands at the shelves with his back to the room.

THEODORE
He broke into your house. He put a hand over your daughter's mouth.

THEO
To stop her.

THEODORE
From what?

THEO
From finishing your sentence.

Theodore turns.

THEODORE
And you hit him in the face.

THEO
Yes.

THEODORE
That's who you're going to trust.

THEO
He didn't hit back.

Theodore says nothing. Theo looks at the foot of the page. A long gray smear lies there, rubbed to nothing.

THEO (CONT'D)
I want to see all of it.

THEODORE
There is no all of it. There is only what you make of it.

THEO
Show me.

He lays his palm flat on the smear. Graphite blackens the heel of his hand.

The lamp goes out.

EXT. QUARRY POND - DAY (1987)

SUPER: "3:34 P.M."

Sun on wet slate. Steam lifts off every surface.

A boy's right hand swings at his side, graphite smeared along the heel of the palm. Small sneakers run down slate steps, slapping.

At the top of the path, behind them, a bicycle lies on its side in the grass. Its front wheel spins.

The only sounds are sneakers, breath, and water.

The steps end at a flat ledge above the pond. The water is black and smooth. The sky is not in it.

On the ledge lies a red satin jacket, dropped in a heap: RUTLAND RAMS across the back in white script.

Thirty feet out, in the middle of the pond, two heads.

TOMAS ARVIDSEN (13), tall, freckled, red hair plastered to his skull, swims on his back in a gray T-shirt and cutoff shorts. One arm is locked across the chest of NELL (5).

Nell's yellow dress is dark with water. She coughs. Her eyes are wide.

Tomas lifts his head toward the ledge. His whole face goes up.

TOMAS
Theo!

He kicks. Water slaps the slate.

TOMAS (CONT'D)
Theo! Take her hand!

He reaches the foot of the ledge, hooks one arm over the stone, and hoists Nell against the slate with the other.

Her hand comes out of the water, small and open. Her fingers spread.

NELL (5)
Theo?

A boy's right hand rises into the light, graphite on the heel. It reaches down toward hers.

It stops two inches short.

TOMAS (CONT'D)
Theo! Take her hand!

The hand shakes. It does not cross the gap.

Theo's eyes go to the red jacket beside his foot. They go to Tomas's face. They stay there.

Tomas looks up. His mouth is open on the next shout. He does not shout.

Against the sky above him, Theo's face: the mouth opens, the lips drawn back from the teeth. The eyes narrow. Both go. The face is blank.

Tomas's lips are blue. His arm shakes on the slate. He nods, small and quick.

He drives Nell up the stone with his free hand. She scrabbles over the lip on her belly and lies coughing beside Theo's sneakers.

Tomas's arm slips. His chin goes under. He comes up and looks at Theo.

He says nothing.

His arm slides off the stone. He goes under without a sound.

A ring spreads from the spot where he went under. A chewed pencil floats up through it, rolls on the black surface, and sinks.

The ring reaches the ledge and fades against the slate. Theo's sneakers are dry.

Nell sits up, shivering. She looks at her brother.

NELL (5)
Theo?

His right hand hangs in the air. It sinks to his side.

Feet pound down the steps. A QUARRYMAN (40s) in a hard hat runs past Theo, shouting, and dives off the ledge.

Water explodes. Theo does not turn.

The quarryman surfaces, gasps, and goes under again. Theo turns and walks up the steps.

At the top he passes the bicycle. The front wheel does not turn.

He walks on across the grass. His hands swing at his sides. They are dry.

INT. THE VERSO - THE STUDY - CONTINUOUS

The lamp burns low and orange. Theo's breath fogs in the cold.

He sits at the desk with his palm on the page and his eyes open. The yellow rope at his waist trails across the boards and out through the door.

Theodore stands behind the desk with his hands at his sides.

THEODORE
Did you find the reason?

Theo shakes his head.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
I looked, Theo. Thirty-eight years and every draft. There isn't one. You looked at his jacket and then at his face and you stopped.

THEO
I know.

THEODORE
Let me give you one. Fear. Shock. Grief. I'll write it so well you'll weep when you read it.

THEO
No.

THEODORE
You'll spend the rest of your life not knowing.

THEO
Yes.

THEODORE
Nobody can live like that.

THEO
Then I'll be a man who doesn't know.

He lifts his palm. The gray smear at the foot of the page sharpens into three lines of slanted cursive in fresh, dark graphite.

He reads them aloud.

THEO (CONT'D)
"You don't have to be brave."

His voice catches.

THEO (CONT'D)
"You just have to be quick."

Theodore's mouth opens. Nothing comes out.

THEO (CONT'D)
"Say my name when you tell it."

THEODORE
He's a boy who drowned. He can't forgive you.

THEO
He didn't write "forgive."

Theo takes the green notebook from inside his coat and opens it on the desk to the last written page. A child's pencil handwriting, round and careful:

Theodore reached into the black water and took her hand, and

He takes out the chewed pencil. Tooth marks run the length of it.

THEODORE
If you write that, you're on the record. Priya. The board. Every reader you ever had. A man who stood there.

THEO
Yes.

THEODORE
And June?

Theo looks at June. She sleeps in the armchair, her palms white.

THEO
She knows. I told her in the kitchen.

THEODORE
You don't know what happens to her if you do this.

THEO
No. I know what happens if I sign.

He strikes a line through THEODORE. Above it, in his own hand, he writes:

Tomas Arvidsen, thirteen,

He bends to the end of the line and writes on. His lips move with the pencil.

she lived, and he did not, and I stood there.

Theodore leans across the desk.

THEODORE
Write it if you have to. Don't read it aloud.

THEO
That's the part that counts.

THEODORE
Theo.

Theo reads.

THEO (CONT'D)
"Tomas Arvidsen, thirteen, reached into the black water and took her hand, and she lived, and he did not, and I stood there."

The last word leaves his mouth. The Study goes silent.

The brown-black lines on Theo's collarbone and ribs lift off his skin and rise through his open collar in curls of steam.

Between his shoulder blades a pencil scratches across his back, slow and firm, one long line and then another. He arches, one hand reaching behind him.

On the shelves, the spines go white one at a time: SLATE. A ROOM CALLED AFTERNOON. THE UNDERSTORY. The shelves stand full of blank white books.

Theodore looks at the shelves. He looks at his own hands. The edges of his fingers go gray.

THEODORE
You will never write a sentence like mine again.

THEO
No.

THEODORE
They'll notice.

THEO
Let them. I'll tell them why.

Black water seeps up between the floorboards. It spreads under the desk and the armchair.

Theo gets up and crosses to June. He kneels and takes her hand.

THEO (CONT'D)
June.

Her eyelids do not move.

THEO (CONT'D)
June Elise--

His mouth stays open on the second name. Nothing follows.

THEO (CONT'D)
June...

The yellow rope at his waist trembles. Voices come out of its strands, thin and flat.

MARA (V.O.)
June Elise Lindqvist-Hale!

NELL (V.O.)
June! June Elise!

Theo looks at the rope. He looks at June.

THEO
June Elise Lindqvist-Hale.

Her fingers curl around his.

The water reaches the legs of the armchair. The chair lifts. Her hand slips out of his.

The walls come loose. The sheets of struck-through handwriting peel away and drift up into the dark. The shelves and the ceiling go with them.

The flood climbs past the knees, the waist, the chest. The armchair spins away across the floor, tips, and drops June under the water.

THEO (CONT'D)
June!

He plunges after her. The current throws him back against the desk. He claws up onto it and kneels on the blotter, streaming.

The desk is an island, its top level with the water. The green-shaded lamp burns on it, a pool of orange light on flat black water.

Nothing breaks the surface.

THEO (CONT'D)
June!

At the edge of the light, the water bulges.

A boy wades into the lamplight, chest-deep, with June held against him. Her head rests on his shoulder. Her face is clear of the water.

It is Tomas: thirteen, freckled, red hair plastered down, a purple bruise on his cheekbone.

He lifts her toward the desk.

TOMAS
Take her hand.

Her small hand hangs open in the air past the edge of the desk.

Theo's right hand reaches for it. It shakes. It stops two inches short.

TOMAS (CONT'D)
Take her hand.

Theo looks at Tomas's face. He does not move.

THEO
Now.

His hand crosses the two inches and closes on hers.

He hauls. June comes up out of the water into his arms, limp and streaming. He lays her on the blotter and turns her on her side.

She coughs up water. Her eyes open.

JUNE
Dad?

THEO
I'm here.

She grips his sleeve with both hands.

Tomas hooks one arm over the edge of the desk. His chin rests on the wood. His arm shakes.

He looks up at Theo.

Theo goes down on his stomach on the blotter and holds out his hand.

THEO (CONT'D)
Tomas.

Tomas looks at the hand.

It does not shake.

Tomas takes it.

Theo hauls. It takes his whole back. Tomas comes up over the edge of the desk and falls on his side on the blotter, gasping.

The water stops running off him. His hair dries from the roots out. His shirt dries. He sits up and plucks at his own dry sleeve.

THEO (CONT'D)
I hit you.

Tomas touches the bruise on his cheekbone. He shrugs. A lopsided grin splits his freckled face.

Theo laughs, a cracked sound, and wipes his face with his wrist.

The flood drains out through the floor with a long sucking sound. Black boards shine under the lamp. The walls are gone. The shelves are gone.

Gray flakes drift down out of the dark and settle on the boards.

Theodore stands alone in the middle of the floor in his pressed white shirt. The shirt is dry. A seam runs up his collar and across his jaw, gray inside.

He looks at the three of them on the desk.

THEODORE
I only wanted to be the one who did it.

Theo stands, June against his side.

THEO
So did I.

Theodore's face loosens. He looks at Tomas. His throat works.

THEODORE
Tomas.

Tomas lifts his chin.

THEODORE (CONT'D)
Thank you.

He holds out his right hand, palm up. A thread of brown-black ink uncurls from his fingertips and crosses the air to Theo's open hand.

It touches Theo's palm, sinks into the skin, and is gone.

The rest of Theodore comes apart in gray flakes: hand, arm, shoulders, face. The flakes fall to the boards and lie there.

Theo closes his hand.

Tomas picks up the green notebook and the chewed pencil from the blotter. He slides the notebook inside Theo's coat.

He takes Theo's free hand, lays the pencil in the palm, and folds the fingers over it, one at a time.

Theo lets him.

The yellow rope snaps taut at Theo's waist. It drags him backward off the desk with June in his arms. His heels leave the desktop.

Tomas stands on the desk with his hands in his pockets, gray flakes settling on his dry hair and shoulders.

His lips shape two words: Go on.

INT. THE VERSO - ASCENDING

The rope hauls Theo and June up through the dark, past the rows of hanging sheets. The sheets are blank and white.

Below them, the squares of floor are lit by single bulbs. In each square a gesture finishes.

The twelve children close their books and stand together.

The man in the wedding suit knocks. A door appears under his knuckles and swings open on a lit room and music.

The woman in the hospital gown lifts the receiver. The cord runs to a wall. She says hello and smiles.

At the school desk, Walter Pruitt's typewriter strikes a key. It makes a sound.

A sheet of paper rolls up out of it, typed across the top: BY WALTER PRUITT. Walter looks up into the dark and raises one hand.

Far below, between the squares, a boy walks away across the gray silt with his hands in his pockets. Dry footprints form behind him, one at a time.

EXT. QUARRY POND - DAWN

Gray light, fog on the water. Mara and Nell stand braced on the ledge with the yellow rope taut between them.

Mara's palms are raw. Nell's forearm is wrapped in rope to the elbow.

The rope jerks. They haul, hand over hand.

The pond breaks. Theo's head and shoulders come up, gasping, June against his chest. Her hair streams. Her eyes are open.

Mara drops her end of the rope and steps off the ledge. The water takes her to the knees, the thighs, the waist.

She takes June out of his arms.

MARA
Breathing. She's breathing.

She carries June up onto the slate, lays her on the coat she left there, and wraps it around her. June coughs. Mara chafes her arms.

JUNE
Mom?

MARA
I've got you.

Theo wades to the ledge. His arms shake. The slate lip stands at his chest, wet and steep.

Nell kneels at the edge and holds out her hand.

Theo looks at it. His own hand does not shake. He takes hers.

THEO
Nell.

NELL
After.

THEO
It's after.

Nell looks at him a long moment.

NELL
Yes. It is.

She hauls. He comes up over the lip onto the slate on his stomach and lies there with the water running off him.

June lies wrapped in Mara's coat, teeth chattering. She turns her head toward him.

JUNE
Dad.

THEO
I'm here.

JUNE
Who saved her?

Theo looks at Nell. He looks back at June.

THEO
His name was Tomas Arvidsen. He was thirteen.

JUNE
Tomas Arvidsen.

THEO
Yes.

June closes her eyes.

Nell pulls Theo's sodden coat and shirt up his back. Between his shoulder blades, in slanted pencil:

T.A. - CHIEF READER

Water streams over it. The pencil does not run.

NELL
What is that?

THEO
What does it say?

NELL
T.A. Chief reader.

Theo puts his forehead down on the slate.

THEO
Tomas Arvidsen.

Nell lays her palm flat over the letters and leaves it there.

Mara kneels beside June with one hand on her daughter's hair. She looks across at Theo. He lies with his face turned to the sky.

THEO (CONT'D)
Perry Street.

MARA
What?

THEO
The radiator. It knocked all night.

A laugh bursts out of her.

MARA
You told me it was ghosts.

THEO
You told me it was the boiler.

MARA
It was the boiler.

THEO
I know.

MARA
Café Orso.

THEO
I owe you a scone.

MARA
You owe me several.

The fog lifts off the pond. The paling sky lies in the water: the pines, a smear of pink, the last star.

Nell looks down at it. Nobody speaks.

INT. ALDER HILL MEMORY CARE - DAYROOM - DAY

Rain on the glass doors and the garden beyond them. The man at the window, hands clasped behind him.

The two women at the table with a jigsaw puzzle, one piece missing. The woman with the walker in the doorway.

Ingrid sits at the corner table folding washcloths. A basin of water at her elbow. She dips a cloth, wrings it, folds it in thirds, stacks it.

INGRID
One in. Two in.

Theo comes in from the rain, hair dripping, his coat dark with water. Nell follows him.

He crouches beside Ingrid's chair.

THEO
Mom.

Ingrid looks up. She cups his wet face in her hands.

INGRID
Tomas! Look at--

She stops. Her thumbs move on his cheekbones.

INGRID (CONT'D)
Theo.

THEO
Yes.

INGRID
You're wet.

THEO
I went in the water, Mom.

INGRID
Theo came back wet.

At the word "wet," everyone in the room turns toward the glass doors. The man at the window. The two women. The woman with the walker.

Then, together, they turn and look at Theo. The man at the window nods.

Theo covers his mother's hands with his own.

Ingrid's eyes move past him to the woman standing at his shoulder.

INGRID (CONT'D)
He sees you now.

Nell does not answer. Her chin shakes.

Ingrid takes a cloth from the basin, wrings it, folds it in thirds, and stacks it.

INGRID (CONT'D)
One in.

She does it again.

INGRID (CONT'D)
Two in.

She dips a third cloth. She wrings it and folds it. She holds it out to Nell.

INGRID (CONT'D)
Three in.

Nell takes the cloth. She presses it against her mouth.

EXT. QUARRY TURNOUT - MORNING

SUPER: "FRIDAY"

Sun on wet gravel. The station wagon sits at the turnout, engine off. Theo stands in front of the granite slab with his hands at his sides.

The marigolds in the mason jar at its base are brown.

The inscription is whole again:

TOMAS ARVIDSEN
1974 - 1987
HE REACHED FOR HER

Gravel crunches. MARIT ARVIDSEN (82) comes along the path in rubber boots and a quarryman's wool cap, a canvas bag on her arm.

Her face is broad and weathered, the freckles gone to age spots. She stops at the edge of the gravel and looks at him.

MARIT
You're the Lindqvist boy.

THEO
Yes, ma'am.

She comes to the slab. She sets down the bag, takes the old jar, empties it onto the gravel, and fills it from a thermos.

She takes fresh marigolds from the bag and arranges them. She does not look at him.

MARIT (CONT'D)
You've been standing there a while.

THEO
I came to tell you something.

MARIT
Then tell it.

Theo's hands open and close at his sides.

THEO
On the fourteenth of August, 1987, your son swam my sister to the ledge. I was standing on it. He told me to take her hand.

Marit's hands stop on the flowers.

THEO (CONT'D)
I didn't.

A bird calls somewhere in the pines.

MARIT
They said you were home.

THEO
I wasn't.

MARIT
Thirty-eight years, they said you were home.

THEO
I know.

She turns and looks at him for the first time.

MARIT
How old were you?

THEO
Nine.

MARIT
He was thirteen.

THEO
Yes.

MARIT
Did he say anything? At the end.

THEO
No. He looked at me. He nodded.

Marit's mouth shuts hard. She turns to the stone and lays her hand on the granite.

THEO (CONT'D)
Tomas chewed pencils to splinters. He wrote in the margins of everything I wrote. He was the best reader I ever had.

He takes the green notebook and the chewed pencil from inside his coat and holds them out.

THEO (CONT'D)
These are his. I'm sorry.

Marit takes the notebook. She opens it. In the margin beside a child's handwriting, in pencil:

best part so far

Her thumb moves over the words. Her lips move with them.

She takes the pencil. Her thumb finds the tooth marks.

MARIT
He ruined every one.

She holds the pencil against her chest.

MARIT (CONT'D)
Say it again.

THEO
Tomas.

MARIT
Again.

THEO
Tomas Arvidsen.

Her eyes close.

MARIT
Thank you for saying it.

She takes his hand in both of hers and holds it. He lets her.

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DUSK

The dust sheets are gone. The window over the sink stands open. Wet leaves lie on the sill. No lamp is lit.

Through the doorway to the hall: at the far end, the white door stands open, paint chips on the floorboards in front of it.

Inside, a narrow bed with a yellow coverlet and a duffel bag on it.

NELL (O.S.)
Dinner in ten.

On the bookshelf, three paperbacks stand together, titles legible, spines aligned. There is no gap.

Theo sits at the table with a pencil and a new spiral notebook. On its cover, in June's neat block capitals: THEO - BOOKS (DO).

His laptop is open, the screen dark.

His sleeves are rolled to the elbow. His forearms are bare.

He listens to the wall behind the stove. No scratching. He nods, small and quick.

His phone buzzes on the table. A voicemail from WALTER PRUITT. He taps the speaker.

WALTER (V.O.)
Theo. Walter Pruitt. I seem to have been mislaid for some days and found again on my own doorstep, which I'm told reflects well on someone's housekeeping. There are forty-one books on my shelves. I'd be obliged if you rang me. And I understand you owe me a name.

The corner of Theo's mouth lifts. He opens the notebook to the first page and writes.

For Walter Pruitt

He turns the page and writes in plain letters.

I was nine. I don't know why I didn't move.

He reads it aloud, low.

THEO
"I was nine. I don't know why I didn't move."

Nothing happens. The ink stays on the paper. His forearm stays bare.

He breathes out. He picks up the phone and dials. It rings twice.

PRIYA (V.O.)
Theo?

THEO
You asked me for one sentence.

PRIYA (V.O.)
I asked for pages.

THEO
I know. I have one.

He reads it to her. A long silence on the line.

PRIYA (V.O.)
That's not like you.

THEO
No.

PRIYA (V.O.)
...Send me the second.

Theo hangs up. He bends over the notebook and the pencil starts the second line.

June appears in the doorway with her laptop held against her chest.

JUNE
Dad?

Theo's pencil keeps moving. It stops in the middle of a word.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Can I read you my story?

Theo sets the pencil down across the page.

THEO
Now.

He pushes the notebook aside. June crosses the kitchen, pulls out the chair across from him, and opens the laptop.

JUNE
"Chapter One. The lighthouse had no keeper, only a lamp that wouldn't go out."

She reads on, her whole face lit. Theo listens, his whole face turned to her.

At the end of the paragraph her eyes flick up to him. He nods, small and quick.

She smiles and reads on.

EXT. QUARRY POND - DUSK

The pond at dusk, flat and smooth. The last pink in the clouds, the dark line of the pines, and the first star lie in the water.

A ring spreads outward from the center of the pond, slow and wide. Nothing disturbs the water above it.

The ring reaches the ledge. It laps the slate and is gone.

BLACK.

THE END